played a vital role in forging alliances with the socialist leader Ram Manohar Lohia, which had powered the Jan Sangh's growth in the late 1960s and '70s. His absence from the founding moment of the BJP, a successor to the Jan Sangh, was conspicuous enough for newspapers to interpret it as a sign of discord. When asked, L.K. Advani denied any such rift. He clarified that Deshmukh himself had asked Vajpayee to exclude him from active participation in 'organisational affairs' when the new party was formed.[33] He had moved instead to Gonda, Madhya Pradesh, and later to Chitrakoot, to work on rural education and farming cooperatives. His absence was important enough for Vajpayee to bring it up in his opening speech, clarifying that Nanaji Deshmukh was away because he was doing 'constructive work and not out of any differences'.[34]

Deshmukh, who was posthumously awarded the Bharat Ratna (Jewel of India)—India's highest civilian honour—by the Modi government in 2019, never returned to politics. He did, however, speak in favour of the Congress's Rajiv Gandhi on the eve of the 1984 general election after Indira Gandhi's assassination, saying he deserved 'cooperation and sympathy' for larger causes.[35] The 1984 election resulted in just two of 514 parliamentary seats for the BJP: the lowest point in its electoral history. Rajiv Gandhi won a full majority in Parliament, the last time any party did so until Modi's triumph in 2014. At least some reports of the time said that many BJP 'active workers who were RSS people generally preferred the Congress (I)' in the 1984 poll.[36] Whether this is true or not, it was indicative of an unease within the party about the turn away from issues of cultural Hindu nationalism.

The Jan Sangh's foray into the Janata Party had been an organisational experiment that ended in failure. Yet, up until the late 1980s, the BJP continued its experiment with ideological flexibility, a legacy of its dalliance with the Janata Party. It pivoted back to cultural nationalism in 1986 with the Ram Temple agitation after the Rajiv Gandhi government enabled the opening of the locks on the disputed Babri Masjid for 'Hindu worshippers' on 1 February.[37] The BJP formally embraced the political aim of building a Ram Temple—an agitation initiated by the RSS-affiliated Vishwa Hindu Parishad